Week 16

JOURNEY

JOURNEY: ADVOCATES® · LEADER HANDOUT · UNIT 4 · LESSON 4

Story

BIG IDEA

We love great stories because we bear the image of God, the source of story itself, and that is another pointer to him. Now halfway through the curriculum, take a simple midterm: have students teach back what they've learned, and look honestly at where you got stuck.

Key points from the Leader Video

1. Students need to see that story comes from God. We can tell great stories because we reflect his image, another pointer that he exists.
2. Look for redemptive and salvation themes in stories: your own, students', someone you know, a book or a movie. Many stories carry biblical themes.
3. You're officially halfway through the curriculum, so evaluate how the year is going. Call it your midterm, with two simple suggestions.
4. First, have students pick a favorite lesson or topic and teach it back or lead a discussion. If they can communicate it accurately, they've got it.
5. Second, look at where you got stuck: research more, find another video, or bring in an apologetics expert from the list at AwanaYM.org.
6. If you're struggling, reach out by email, Twitter or Facebook. The In Two Minutes videos for students invite further questions in their comments.

FOR YOU

Before club: think it through yourself.

1. Which topic from the first half left me least comfortable, and what would help?
2. Which students could I invite to teach a lesson back to the group?
3. Where in my own story can I see God's redemption at work?

ASK YOUR GROUP

In small group: questions to ask your students.

1. What's a favorite movie or book of yours, and where do you see redemption in its story?
2. Why do you think people everywhere love telling and hearing stories?
3. How could our love of story point to God, and what makes that hard to accept?
4. Which lesson from this year could you teach back to the group, and what would you say?
5. Where have you seen something broken in your own life turn into something good?

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The full transcript

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

Story comes from God

0:05 We all love a great story, so this lesson should be a fun one. But I want you to remember that students need to see that story originates from God himself. Again, this is another pointer to God, showing students that God exists because we have these things — because we have such a thing as story, because we can tell great stories. And as people who reflect the image of God, we get that from him. It's awesome, and hopefully your students will see that at the end of this unit.

Finding redemptive themes

0:37 A fun way to do this is to find different stories, whether it be your own story, or maybe some of their stories, or the story of someone you know. It could be a book; it could be a movie. But within those stories you want to find redemptive themes, themes of salvation, those kinds of things. And you'd be surprised how many different stories are actually based off of, or have buried within them, biblical themes.

Your midterm

1:01 So now you are officially halfway through the curriculum. You've had some time to take inventory of where you are — where you are with your students, with your leaders, with your small groups and the community, and those types of things. You've had a chance to step back, take a look at all of that, and see how the year is going so far. Now it's time to evaluate. This might not be something you're used to doing, but I highly encourage it. I think it's really, really helpful in moving forward. So we're going to call this your midterm. Get ready, because you have a quiz and a test coming up and you're going to need — no, I'm just kidding. I just have two suggestions, and it's super simple.

Have students teach it back

1:43 The first thing is something I've been doing for years with students that I think is awesome: have them do something. Instead of just having them listen and maybe engage in discussion, have some students — you might pick out one, you might pick out several — choose one of their favorite lessons, a favorite topic or a part of a lesson, and either teach it back, lead a discussion, or do something with it. That's fun. It doesn't mean they have to be crazy or super complicated, but it helps you and helps your leaders get an idea of whether your students are digesting this and are able to communicate it back.

2:18 If they can accurately communicate something back to you, they've got it. It's a simple, easy way to determine whether or not they're tracking with you. You can ask them all day long and they might say yes, but when they try to say it, they're all over the place and they don't get it.

But if they can teach it back, it will compel other students, and it changes things up. It's kind of fun, it's something different, and they can have some fun with it. This is a really good time to do that, now that you are halfway through.

Where you got stuck

2:47 The second thing is to take a look at where you struggled. You don't want to keep moving forward if for some reason you got stuck on something. So now might be a good time to think about how to unstick yourself from that particular topic. Maybe there's something you just weren't comfortable with, or something they didn't get, or a place where you want some reinforcements. Maybe there were some additional questions that you just couldn't answer. Maybe it's simply a matter of you sitting down, doing some more research, and figuring it out — that would be awesome. Maybe it's an additional video you find someplace else, or maybe it's bringing in the experts, bringing in somebody.

3:26 On our website at AwanaYM.org, we are going to have for you a list of potential people that you can get a hold of. I can't guarantee they're going to come, but you can get a hold of them to see if you can schedule a time to bring in one of many apologetics experts to help you, or to do a special event, or to do something to further the sticky point or just further a discussion that was already started.

Great job so far

3:53 So great job getting this first half of the year completed. I know these first few months probably have been difficult. There have been some topics you had to tackle that maybe you've been a little less than comfortable with, and some things that maybe have been challenging for you and your students. But I know you have done a phenomenal job of getting the information to the students, engaging with them at a high level, making this stuff super relevant, and stressing its importance as they continue their walk with Christ.

4:26 And if you're struggling anywhere, for any reason, on anything, please reach out to us. We are here to help you. You can email us, and you can hit us up on Twitter or Facebook. We have a series of videos called In Two Minutes that we designed specifically for students, and in the comments below those we invite students to ask additional questions. Through those questions, we will continue to add additional videos and answer additional questions. Again, we are here to help you. Please reach out to us, and we will help you in any way that we can.